

3rd Degree Black Belt Test Essay

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As I approach the start of my 3rd degree black belt testing, I think deeply about what my career in Taekwondo has contributed to my life. I started Taekwondo when I was only 9. Now, 8 years later, I can see a significant effect on my development and growth throughout the years. Taekwondo has been a constant throughout my life, and I know that one of the biggest things that Taekwondo has done for me was help me learn to keep pushing through dark times.

Outside of Taekwondo, I've lived a life similar to most other people my age. I attended school, I gained and lost friends. I dealt with hardships and health issues, and I've been challenged physically, but even with all of this happening in my life, Taekwondo has continued to be a constant part of my life, helping me maintain balance and keeping myself well rounded. When I struggled with mental health, Taekwondo was there to be a refuge. When I was diagnosed with diabetes, even learning to adjust my lifestyle, Taekwondo helped me stay physically active and learn how to manage, especially during the COVID pandemic. This persistence has helped me learn how to keep going, even when things look like they can't turn around, and I think that the development of persistence and resilience has been one of the biggest benefits of Taekwondo for me.

However, though resilience is one of the biggest benefits for taekwondo for me, it isn't the only benefit it has had for me. Taekwondo helped me develop respect and honour in all parts of my life by teaching me how to respect people, even those you don't like. I am able to respect people for who they are, and not for how I perceive them because of Taekwondo. This respect has helped me advance quicker and create meaningful relationships with people around me. With classmates each semester, with coworkers, and with other students at the studio.

I believe that if I had not been a part of Taekwondo, these life lessons would not have been developed until far later in my life, and there would be a lot more hardships on the way to

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learning them. Instead, having participated and been a part of Jeons World Martial Arts (JWMA), I have seen these life skills displayed perfectly by my instructors, and have been able to learn each skill without having to struggle through life without them first.

These skills represent some of my strongest morals and standards in life. I live by a code of respect, loyalty, resilience, and hard work. I apply all of these morals to each and every aspect of my life, and although I am not perfect in applying them, I strive to think of them in every interaction I have with others. From a simple request for help on the mat, to a question to a professor after class or a hard assignment with a short due date, I try to be respectful to everyone, loyal and reliable for all, resilient and persistent in the things I strive for, and hard working to attain the goals I've set.

I believe these 4 morals form the core principles in my life, and dictate the majority of my interactions. Without these morals, I would be an entirely different person. Without respect, I would be harsher and more unfriendly, and I wouldn't understand the accomplishments of others. Without loyalty, I would lose relationships with those around me, with my friends, associates, and coworkers. Without resilience, I wouldn't finish projects, continue through goals, and I would give up easier. I wouldn't complete things if they were difficult, and wouldn't learn from them. And without putting in hard work, I wouldn't even be able to start projects or goals I have started. With these skills, I am able to be the person I am, and work hard to attain the goals I have set, and even now, I apply them as I think about my 3rd degree black belt test.

To prepare for my black belt test, I have worked hard to prepare myself both physically and mentally. One way that I have prepared is by thinking about the way I approach situations, solve problems, and the effort I put into the things I do. Through this, I have found ways that I am able to improve myself in many aspects of life. I have been able to identify the issues that

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hinder my performance in different aspects, and think about ways I can remedy these problems. Some of the areas of life this has helped most in is school and Taekwondo. By improving my school life and improving myself in Taekwondo, I am better prepared to put my full effort into my 3rd degree black belt test.

Along with this, I have prepared myself physically by getting into a workout routine that benefits me in all areas. This routine helps me keep my mood steady, improve my physical abilities and performance, and keep myself versatile. Without a routine to keep myself fit and active, I would struggle to participate to my fullest abilities during my test, and would hinder my performance overall, in and leading up to the test. My routine involves workouts spread throughout each week that focus on different parts of my body, allowing one muscle group to recover while focusing on another. Through this, I can also eliminate the concern of hurting myself during the test.

Through eliminating each of these concerns and potential issues, I can focus more clearly on my test ahead of me. As we continue to near my black belt test, I will continue to focus and identify more areas of concern that I can resolve before my test. I plan to be able to commit myself fully to my test, and give 110% throughout the entire duration of the test.

JWMA has 4 pillars of strength that we go by every moment of our training. The first pillar is the purpose of JWMA. The purpose of Jeons World Martial Arts is to develop oneself physically, mentally, and spiritually, and to have good character. To me, this means that, while JWMA is a martial arts studio determined to teach each student good martial arts, our purpose is also to help students improve themselves in all other categories in life as well. We intend to improve each student physically, through training themselves regularly and pushing each individual's limits. We intend to improve each student mentally, by teaching good standards and

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life-lessons, and showing respect in everything we do. And we intend to improve each student spiritually, helping each student understand good morals, and teaching students how to focus.

Through each of these categories, JWMA is devoted to making the best martial artist.

The second pillar is JWMA's goal. This goal goes by an acronym (ish) , "CANI." CANI stands for Commitment to Constant and Never Ending Improvement. To me, this means that even if you have mastered a skill, there is always improvement in your life and in that skill. Whether it be through applications, understanding, or execution, everything we do as people can be improved, and at JWMA, we intend to try to improve it all.

The third pillar is our success system. This success system can be generalized to be applicable to all aspects of life, however, at JWMA, we use it to create a clear path and method for black belt excellency. The first step in the success system is to have a clear goal in mind. At JWMA, black belt is the goal, however, in other aspects of life, the goal may be anything that you need it to be. However, regardless of what it is, you have to have a driven purpose to achieve the goal. Without this purpose, you will lack motivation to work towards the goal, and will not succeed. The second step is to start now and to practice or train consistently. You can't give up at any time, or take a break, as this will make continuing incredibly hard. Instead, you have to create momentum until you reach your goal, and give 110%. The third step is to strive for excellence and quality. In each step towards your goal, you have to make what you are able to do the best it can be. You have to try for excellence in all the steps up to your goal. The 4th step is correction and repetition. This means that you must analyze what you are doing, and correct them to stay on path towards your goal, and then repeat it over and over again. A good way is to have people that have already achieved your goal, or are farther along, and analyze what they are doing. The 5th step is consistent and constant practice. Without practicing, your goal will always

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be as far away as it was when you started. Even if it seems you may have reached your goal, you have to keep practicing, because you can always become better. The final step is to create extraordinary results for life. Once you've reached your goal, don't just stop. Set higher goals and strive to maintain your achievements.

The fourth and final pillar of JWMA is our 5 levels of mastery. These levels help you identify the amount of effort you are giving, and can give, and help remind us where we want to be. The 5 levels are non-survival level, in which you don't try at all; mediocre level, where you barely try and give minimum effort; comfort zone level, in which you give just enough effort to do what you are told, but you don't go beyond; black belt excellence level, in which you commit to excel and do your best; and mastery level, where you commit to create extraordinary results and push to accomplish far beyond what you aimed for. At JWMA, we always try to strive for mastery level. This motivates us to improve and give our best, even 110%.

These four pillars have dictated a great amount of the accomplishments I've had throughout my time at JWMA. Through these pillars, I have become better not just at the studio, but throughout all aspects of my life and in all ways. I can see the way I looked at things before I attended JWMA, and learned of our pillars. Before I attended JWMA, I didn't do my best in anything I did, and lived in a comfort zone or mediocre level. However, through constant training at JWMA, I've learned to do my best in all areas of life, and, even outside the studio, I strive for black belt excellence and mastery level. I work hard to do my best and give far more than is required. Through these pillars, I have become my personal best, and I strive to continue to be my best throughout all of life.

Testing for 3rd degree black belt means a higher degree of commitment, devotion, and effort is required. Through testing for 3rd degree, I have the responsibility to be a model for

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younger students and consistently demonstrate my best abilities to set a strong example.

However, 3rd degree also means a lot outside of taekwondo. Being a 3rd degree black belt means representing the studio everywhere I go, and ensuring that I follow the standards set there throughout my daily life. These standards show those I interact with and connect with the type of person I am, and the way Taekwondo shapes my daily life.

I am grateful for everyone that has helped my improvement and growth throughout the past 9 years of my Taekwondo career in getting me to where I am. I am grateful for all of the black belt instructors that have seen my potential and helped me reach my goals throughout my time, and for all of the friends and colleagues that have been with me throughout my journey. However, I am especially grateful for my parents, who have supported my journey in many different ways. When I was a colour belt, there were times where I didn't want to go to class, but I am grateful for my parents, who pushed me to go, and helped teach me how to do hard things even if I didn't want to.